

Gender Reckonings

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New Social Theory and Research

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On the Elasticity of Gender Hegemony

Why Hybrid Masculinities Fail to Undermine Gender and Sexual Inequality

Tristan Bridges and C. J. Pascoe

Gender is susceptible to extraordinary change; gender inequality is, by comparison, much more durable. Indeed, shifting gendered styles have been at the center of discussion among masculinities scholars and contemporary social commentators, many claiming that the days of emotional repression, homophobia, and sexism are nearing their end. Consider, for example, some recent trends in masculine expression: the “metrosexual,” the “hipster,” and the “bro.”

The earliest of these, the *metrosexual*, emerged in 1994 (Simpson 1999 [1994]; Barber 2016). This well-coiffed twenty- or thirtysomething, white, educated, professional man likely lived in a city and stylistically laid claim to symbolic territory typically associated with women and gay men (de Casanova, Wetzell, and Speice 2016). This “new heterosexual masculinity, one rooted in consumption and vanity” (Barber 2016) purchased grooming products, wore designer clothing, and spent a great deal of time and money on hygiene and appearance (e.g., Whitehead 2007; Coad 2008; Shugart 2008).

Appearing on the heels of the metrosexual (though echoing earlier gendered expressions [Mailer 1957]), the *hipster* is a white, usually college educated, 20–30-year-old, city-dwelling man, distinguished by tastes such as musical interests, hairstyles, grooming habits, clothing, literary and artistic curiosities, as well as culinary and libation preferences. More countercultural, androgynous, intellectual, creative, and independent than the metrosexual, the hipster draws on a gendered form of nostalgia for masculinities of old—embracing styles of facial hair, dress, or particular cultural artifacts from specific historical periods (at least as those periods are collectively imagined). The rise of the artisanal hipster aesthetic is part of a more general elevation of all manner of “geek masculinities” to new heights of gendered status (Bell 2013).

Other recent expressions of masculinity, such as the *bro*, seem to be less indicative of change. “Bro” is most often used to describe young, white men, connoting a playful, immature, hypermasculine, frat boy, party culture (e.g., Ward 2008, 2015). As a prefix or suffix, “bro” masculinizes all sorts of identities, objects, relationships, and behaviors: “laxbros” (lacrosse players), “brogrammers” (computer programmers), “dudebros” (generic, hypermasculine twentysomethings), “brogurt” (yogurt for men), “brotein” (protein as a dietary supplement), “broga” (yoga for men), and, perhaps most conspicuously, the “bromance.” From movies (*I Love You, Man*, 2009) to social media hashtags (#mancrushmonday), “bromance” describes intense emotional bonds and perhaps even intimate touch between young, straight-identified men (e.g., DeAngelis 2014), forms of homosociality that seem to share little in common with similar relations in relatively recent history (e.g., Bird 1996; Grazian 2007).¹

While by no means an exhaustive list, taken together we suggest that these three emergent configurations of gender illustrate that masculinity is changing. What does it mean for heterosexual men to care deeply about their appearance in ways that are typically associated with women or gay men? What does it mean when men proudly announce intimate relationships with other straight men? Do they herald larger changes in the structure and organization of gender relations and inequality? Can they be seen as

evidence of a general demise of homophobia or sexism? The answer to all of these questions is both “Yes” and “No.” Indeed, the larger question—and one that is more challenging to answer—is what do contemporary transformations in masculinity among historically privileged groups of men *mean*?

The sense that masculinity is changing is nothing new (e.g., Rotundo 1993; Segal 1990; Kimmel 2012). Over a half century ago, Helen Hacker (1957) asked why and how masculinity was transforming, what kinds of new dilemmas and burdens awaited men navigating emerging gendered expectations, and whether changes in masculinity might foreshadow transformations in inequality. Historical evidence suggests that gendered anxieties and discourses that follow shifts in gender relations are recycled. Indeed, while the examples of the metrosexual, the hipster, and the bro are contemporary ones, they indicate that gender is a historical *process*, and that some configurations of practice are more likely during some historical periods than others as patterned responses to transformations in gender relations.

As with previous historical periods during which masculinities were being redefined, the extent of contemporary transformations and their impact and meaning is the source of a great deal of theory, research, and debate (e.g., Connell 1985, 1987, 1995, 2002; Messner 1993; Anderson 2009; Bridges and Pascoe 2014). What we are interested in here is not the fact that change is happening, but how to interpret the *meanings* of these changes. It is tempting to read the metrosexual, the hipster, and the bro as part of a narrative of extraordinary and progressive change—men seem less inhibited by strict expectations of manliness. Indeed, some scholars suggest that the transformations associated with young, white, educated, and class-privileged men are signs of “the declining significance of homophobia” (McCormack 2012). Others argue that contemporary masculinities are no longer organized hierarchically; rather, they are “inclusive” (Anderson 2009) and represent a fundamental challenge to systems of power and inequality. We suggest that symbolic changes in the gender order need to be understood in terms of what they accomplish, but also what they obscure.

To understand these emerging identities as both accomplishing and obscuring gender inequality, we bring Raewyn Connell’s theorization of “symbolic relations” into dialogue with our conceptualization of “hybrid masculinities”—the selective incorporation of identity elements typically associated with various marginalized and subordinated masculinities or femininities into privileged men’s gendered performances and identities (e.g., Demetriou 2001; Messner 2007; Messerschmidt 2010; Arxer 2011; Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2014, 2015). By drawing on the substructures of Connell’s theory of gender relations, we articulate how flexibility in some substructures can work in ways that conceal the resilience of others.

Gender Relations

Drawing on Juliet Mitchells’s (1966) insight that gender inequality was established by a complex yet “specific structure” made up of distinct components, Connell makes sense of gender relations as composed of four constituent parts: power relations, production relations, emotional relations, and symbolic relations (Connell 1987, 2002). These four dimensions of gender relations are interconnected and mutually constitutive. As with other understandings of gender as a social structure (e.g., Lorber 1993; Risman 2004), the identification of these four substructures emerged out of previous feminist theorizing.

As “substructures” (Connell 2004), Connell understood these dimensions of gender relations as working together, though not always to the same ends or with the same means. As such Connell’s theory makes possible an understanding of gender inequality as capable of being challenged and reproduced simultaneously. As Connell notes, however:

The argument does not assume that they are the only discoverable structures, that they exhaust the field. Nor does it claim that they are necessary structures. . . . The argument rests on a gentler, more pragmatic but perhaps more demonstrable claim that with a framework like this we can come to a serviceable understanding of current history. (1987, 97)

Intentionally leaving a theory open like this speaks to this framework's ability to adapt to new contexts and contingencies. Connell's theory of gender relations does more than simply account for change; it actively anticipates change.

Not only do gender relations change, but these changes actually *constitute* gender relations. Gender relations are historically unstable and prone toward crisis, something Connell calls "crisis tendencies." Crisis tendencies are uneven, often affecting gender relations incompletely. While the gender order continually tends toward crisis, Connell suggests that this propensity may have intensified in recent history, producing "a major loss of legitimacy for patriarchy," such that "different groups of men are now negotiating this loss in very different ways" (1995, 202).

Conceptualizing crisis tendencies as an integral feature of gender relations allows us to make sense of historical change by considering the diverse potential embedded within any historical transformation in gender relations. Crisis tendencies speak to the flexibility of systems of power and inequality. Though the history of gender inequality is sometimes presented as a slow but steady march toward equality, Connell's theory makes possible an understanding of progress while contextualizing this potential with a conceptualization of inequality as flexible and adaptive.

Hybrid Masculinities

As relations of power, production, emotions, and symbols change, these changes reverberate throughout the gender order. Building on the dimension of symbolic relations in particular, the concept of hybrid masculinities attests to the flexibility of gender inequality. Hybrid masculinities illustrate a great deal of change among symbolic and emotional relations—transformations that obscure the fact that power relations have been less challenged than it initially seems.

Hybrid masculinities refer to the selective incorporation of elements of identity typically associated with various marginalized and subordinated masculinities and—at times—femininities into privileged men's gender performances and identities (e.g., Demetriou 2001; Messner 2007; Messerschmidt 2010; Arxer 2011; Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2014).² These transformations include men's assimilation, among others, of "bits and pieces" (Demetriou 2001, 350) of identity projects coded as "gay" (e.g., Hennessy 1995; Demetriou 2001; Heasley 2005; Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2015), "Black" (e.g., Ward 2008; Hughey 2012), or "feminine" (e.g., Arxer 2011; Wilkins 2009; Schippers 2000; Messerschmidt 2010).

Research on hybrid masculinities points to a patterned set of consequences associated with the processes of incorporating elements of the identities of various Others. Hybrid masculinities work in ways that reproduce contemporary systems of gender, race, class, and sexual inequality, but, importantly, obscure this process as it is happening. The emergence of hybrid masculinities indicates that normative constraints associated with masculinity are shifting, and shows that these shifts have largely taken place in ways that have sustained existing ideologies and systems of power and inequality (e.g., Messner 1993, 2007; Demetriou 2001; Messerschmidt 2010; Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2014, 2015).

The interpretation of changes in gender relations provided by our conceptualization of "hybrid masculinity" directly critiques a growing body of literature that suggests that new configurations of identity and practice are best understood as *resistance* to gender and sexual inequality. This "inclusivity" framework (Anderson 2009; McCormack 2012) suggests that these changes in gender relations represent important, lasting, and serious changes in various dimensions of gender inequality. Yet historical work on masculinity documents that it is a category of identity characterized by internal and dialectical contradictions (e.g., Kimmel 2012; Aboim 2010) and that hegemonic configurations have demonstrated extraordinary elastic properties over time, incorporating new modes of behavior and practice in periods of crisis (e.g., Messner 1993, 2007; Connell 1995; Demetriou 2001; Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2014, 2015; de Boise 2015), and taking on unique forms in different regions and local contexts (Connell and

Messerschmidt 2005). This chapter provides an alternate analysis of contemporary shifts in masculinities not as uniform challenges to gender and sexual inequality, but as complicated processes that have the collective effect of obscuring inequality.

The concept of hybrid masculinities grew out of analytic limitations associated with Connell's theorization of hegemonic masculinity (Demetriou 2001). In analyzing straight-identified men's assimilation of elements of "gay male culture," Demetriou suggested that the concept of hegemonic masculinity, which had at its core a symbolic distance from "subordinated masculinity" (a configuration Connell [1987, 1992, 1995] argued was best represented by gay men), could not account for why straight men might adopt the styles of subordinated men. This is, for Demetriou, inconsistent with a Gramscian conceptualization of "hegemony":

Whereas for Gramsci the process is essentially a dialectical one that involves reciprocity and mutual interaction between the class that is leading and the groups that are led, Connell understands the process in a more elitist way where subordinate and marginalized masculinities have no effect on the construction of the hegemonic model. (Demetriou 2001, 345)

As such, Demetriou suggests that hegemonic masculinity is better understood as a "hegemonic masculine bloc" capable of appropriating "what appears pragmatically useful and constructive for the project of domination at a particular historical moment" (2001, 345). While it may seem that the adoption of elements associated with gay men by straight men is a significant movement away from hierarchical gendered relations, Demetriou suggests something much more dynamic—that the incorporation of "bits and pieces [of gay male culture] . . . [produce] new, hybrid configurations of gender practice that enable them to reproduce their dominance over women [and other men] in historically novel ways" (2001, 350–51). The appropriation of elements of subordinated and marginalized "Others" into configurations of hegemonic masculinities works to recuperate existing systems of power and inequality.

Demetriou's understanding, however, presupposes concrete social groups in definite relations of alliance and subordination. Our identity-based approach situates these practices as much more fluid and dynamic. As such, our theorizing of hybrid masculinities builds on—rather than opposes—Connell's framework. It is not the case, for instance, that young, straight, white men are the only ones "playing" with masculinity. Nor is it necessarily true that young men are *intentionally* playing with masculinity in ways that either maintain or conceal gender inequality. Our conceptualization of "hybrid masculinities" captures the dynamic processes through which some groups receive a qualitatively different set of patterned consequences for their participation and have a qualitatively different set of considerations at stake in participating in the first place.

Our theorization of "hybrid masculinity" connects a consistent finding across a collection of research that has shown that hybrid masculinities are broadly associated with at least three distinct consequences that exacerbate, reflect, and conceal existing inequalities in patterned ways (e.g., Bridges and Pascoe 2014). First, hybrid masculine practices often work in ways that create discursive space between privileged groups of men and hegemonic masculinity, enabling some to frame themselves as outside of existing systems of privilege and inequality—something we label *discursive distancing*. Second, contemporary hybrid masculinities are often premised on the notion that the masculinities available to young, white, straight men are less meaningful than the identities of various Others, whose identities were at least partially produced by collective struggles for rights and recognition. We call this process *strategic borrowing*. Third, hybrid masculinities work to fortify symbolic and social boundaries between (racial, gender, sexual, class-based) groups—further entrenching, and often concealing, inequality in historically novel ways. We refer to this consequence as *fortifying boundaries*.

Collectively, these patterned consequences exemplify the processes by which meanings and practices of hegemonic masculinity change over time in ways that have sustained the structure of institutionalized gender regimes to advantage men collectively over women and some men over others (Connell and

Messerschmidt 2005). Similar to Connell's (1987, 1995) conceptualization of the four substructures of gender relations as interrelated and overlapping, we see each of the consequences we identify here as heuristic devices that enable us to examine the meanings of contemporary shifts in gender identities, relations, and inequality. Below, we provide more detail from research that highlights the three processes as interrelated, yet distinct.

Discursive Distancing

Research on men's profeminist, political, and grooming activities illustrates how hybrid masculinities can work in ways that discursively distance men from hegemonic masculinity as they also (often more subtly) align themselves with it. "Bromances," for instance, are instructive—they are, on the surface, a relationship that would seem to reduce the distance between hegemonic masculinity and intimacy between men in a way that questions the centrality of homophobia to contemporary masculinities. Yet the very language to describe these relationships—"bro"—works to symbolically enshrine heterosexuality by establishing distance from same-sex eroticism even while seemingly engaging in same-sex intimacy. In this way, "bro" works as both a symbol and discourse associated with a dominant configuration of white, heterosexual masculinity (Ward 2015). An analysis of men's antisexist work and beauty practices documents a similar process of change in symbolic relations that does little to disrupt the systems of power that structure gender and sexual relations more broadly.

Men's participation in antiviolence movements such as Walk a Mile in Her Shoes marches (Bridges 2010) or My Strength Is Not for Hurting campaigns (Masters 2010) illustrates discursive distancing. Walk a Mile marches require that men wear high-heeled shoes and walk one mile protesting violence against women and pledging support to end it. These men are standing in solidarity with women, actively opposing men's violence, and wearing women's clothing—all practices that seem to distance them from hegemonic masculinity. As Bridges (2010) observed, however, march participants can reproduce gender and sexual inequality even as they actively resist it. Participants regularly joked about wearing women's clothing, their (in)ability to walk in heels, and same-sex sexual desire—all of which worked to align them with hegemonic masculinity even as their participation in antiviolence activism distances them from it.

The My Strength Is Not for Hurting campaign—one of few antirape campaigns explicitly directed at men—also works to distance men from hegemonic masculinity through framing rapists as pathological men while depicting the nonrapist as hegemonically masculine. The nonrapist is a "real," "strong" man who is fundamentally different from (the presumably weak and unmanly) rapist. The campaign draws on ideologies about men's inherent "strength" and protectionism ("... is not for hurting") in a way that symbolically reinscribes unequal gender relations. Campaigns like this separate "good" from "bad" men and fail to account for the ways that presenting strength and power as natural resources for men perpetuates gender and sexual inequality even as they are called into question (Murphy 2009; Pascoe and Hollander 2016). Both Walk a Mile marches and the My Strength Is Not for Hurting campaign create some distance between these (good) men who oppose gendered violence and (bad) hegemonically masculine men who presumably support it. Yet, in challenging men's violence against women, both campaigns simultaneously reaffirm hegemonic masculine forms.

Other boundary blurring projects accomplish similar ends. Kristen Barber's (2008, 2016) study of white, middle-class, heterosexual men's interactions with workers in professional men's hair salons illustrates a related dynamic in which some men engage in beauty work formerly coded "feminine." Barber shows how men rely on a rhetoric of expectations associated with professional-class masculinities to justify their participation in the beauty industry while simultaneously naturalizing distinctions between themselves and working-class men, framing the latter as misogynistic and responsible for reproducing gender inequality. Barber highlights the ways these men avoid feminization while simultaneously strengthening their status as class-privileged men. The cost of the salon services excludes working-class men; but more than this, the salons' clients position themselves as more gender and sexually progressive than the nonwhite and working-class men not represented in these places. Thus, the straight, white, educated, and elite men in Barber's study frame costly salon haircuts as a sign of progressive masculinity—a potent symbol they frame as illustrating their status as "new" men (see Messner and Messerschmidt's chapter in this volume).

While bromances, men's prowomen activism, and beauty work may appear to be new, the process of *discursive distancing* is not. As Pierette Hondagneu-Sotelo and Mike Messner argued:

Too often critical discussions of masculinity tend to project atavistic hypermasculine, aggressive, misogynistic masculinity onto relatively powerless men. By comparison, the masculine gender displays of educated, privileged New Men are too often uncritically applauded, rather than skeptically and critically examined. (1994, 215)

Ignoring the intersectional dynamics that inequitably distribute access to specific hybrid masculine forms risks presenting contemporary changes as indicative of transformations in systems of inequality that still exist—albeit in new forms. As Hondagneu-Sotelo and Messner (1994) suggest, men of color, working-class men, and immigrant men, among others, are often implicitly cast as the possessors of regressive masculinities. In fact, when groups of marginalized and subordinated Others craft hybrid gender identities, they often do so with very different consequences and concerns than those of white, middle-class, young, urban men. *Discursive distancing* provides a sensitizing concept to analyze these intersections in finer detail. Part of analyzing transformations in symbolic gender relations must involve a critical assessment of the work accomplished for the groups who get labeled as transformed.

Strategic Borrowing

Configurations of hybrid masculinity associated with privileged groups of men are often premised on the notion that the masculinities they perceive as available to them are meaningless when compared with various “Others.” Indeed, cultural appropriation is a defining characteristic of processes of hybridization—domination through “negotiation” rather than “negation” (e.g., Sinfield 1996; Burke 2009). Research on hybrid masculinities has shown that men who occupy privileged social categories “strategically borrow” symbols associated with various Others in ways that work to reframe themselves as symbolically part of socially subordinated groups.

While challenging inequality may be part of the motivation driving hybrid masculine configurations, research suggests that these practices may also have to do with exploring pleasures that powerful men have been denied by gendered expectations. Relatively privileged men who mobilize hybrid configurations of masculinity gain access to some of the symbolic and emotional pleasures associated with transgression. In this way, hybrid masculinities can also be seen as a form of symbolic tourism—enjoying the pleasures associated with transgressing normative gender and sexual boundaries, but avoiding much of the injustice and pain.

Once made visible by feminist challenge and critique, privileged configurations of masculinity are capable of dramatically reworking the meaning associated with that visibility to recuperate privilege in new ways. Through this process, white men are presented as victims (Messner 1993) and inequality becomes less easily identified. Like Mary Waters's (1990) research documenting white people's relative ignorance of the ethnic flexibility they are afforded, the hybrid identities available to young, straight, white men may be very different from those available to marginalized and subordinated groups. As Patricia Hill Collins writes, “Authentic Black people must be contained—their authentic culture can enter white controlled spaces, but they cannot” (Collins 2004, 177). The strategic borrowing of symbols and styles associated with various marginalized and subordinated “Others” has a patterned set of consequences, research documents. One manifestation of this are hipster masculinities, which borrow bits and pieces from working-class, white masculinity as a way of symbolically laying claim to masculine authenticity.

Strategic borrowing is also at work in the incorporation of gay culture by straight-identified men. The emergence of the identity of the metrosexual seems perhaps the best example of this. Indeed, de Casanova, Wetzel, and Speice's (2015) interviews with metrosexual-identified men indicate that white-collar men embraced this configuration of gender strategically (for career advancement) “rather than [out of] a collective rethinking of masculine norms or a challenge to hegemonic masculinity” (2015, 78). As

culturally dominant models of masculinity assimilate symbols associated with subordinated “Others” and alter the look and feel of contemporary performances of gender, however, these practices do little to challenge men’s structural position of power and authority (Demetriou 2001). Rather, as Demetriou writes,

[w]e are used to seeing masculine power as a closed, coherent, and unified totality that embraces no otherness, no contradiction. This is an illusion that must be done away with because it is precisely through its hybrid and apparently contradictory content that hegemonic masculinity reproduces itself. (2001, 355)

Similarly, by theorizing the symbolic elements of sexuality, Bridges (2014) analyzes the causes and consequences of heterosexual men subjectively identifying aspects of themselves as “gay” in ways that preserve their heterosexuality and simultaneously reinforce existing boundaries between gay and straight individuals and cultures.

Steven Arxer’s (2011) study of interactions between heterosexual men at a college bar documents an analogous practice. The behavior of the men in Arxer’s study is surprisingly different from the competitive, emotionally detached, sexually objectifying practices that characterize straight men’s interactions in Bird’s (1996) or Grazian’s (2007) research. Instead, these men draw on the emotionality presumably displayed by gay men (illustrating flexibility within Connell’s “emotional relations”) to increase their chances of sexually “scoring” with women (providing no real challenge to “power relations”). Thus, while a different collective performance of masculinity than the “the girl hunt” that Grazian (2007) examined or Bird’s (1996) analysis of the “men’s club,” the consequences of performing emotional sensitivity are strikingly similar in terms of sustaining existing systems of power and inequality. Similar consequences occur with racial strategic borrowing among white men (e.g., Hughey 2012; Bridges and Pascoe 2014).

When we frame young, straight, class-privileged, educated, white men’s “new” performances of masculinity solely as indicators of a decline in gender and sexual inequality (e.g., Anderson 2009; McCormack 2012), already marginalized groups of men often end up situated as playing a greater role in perpetuating inequality (Messner 1993; Hondagneu-Sotelo and Messner 1994; Bridges and Pascoe 2014). By framing an extraordinarily privileged group of men as both the embodiment and harbinger of feminist change, social scientists participate in further marginalizing poor men, working-class men, religious men, undereducated men, rural men, and men of color (among others). Even as young, straight, white men borrow from young, gay, black, working-class, rural, or urban men to symbolically boost their masculine capital, research shows that these practices often work to reaffirm these subordinate and marginalized groups as deviant, shoring up existing relations of power and dominance.

Fortifying Boundaries

By co-opting elements of style and performance from less powerful masculinities, young, straight, white men’s hybridizations often obscure the symbolic and social boundaries between groups upon which such practices rely. Through a process we call *fortifying boundaries*, hybrid masculinities further entrench and conceal systems of inequality in historically new ways, often along lines of race, gender, sexuality, and class.

For instance, when men engage in sexual practices that challenge the relationship between normative masculinity and homophobia, they may reify inequality. Jane Ward’s (2008, 2015) research on white straight-identifying men who have sex with other straight-identifying men illustrates this process. Ward documents the ways that, in their search for sexual partners, these men objectify women, reject effeminacy among men, and hypereroticize men of color. They talk about hooking up with other men while watching “pussy porn,” say they do not want to have sex with men who are feminine “sissy la las,” and use stigmatizing language to describe their ideal men-of-color sex partners. Ward calls this particular configuration of practices “dude sex,” implicitly suggesting that sex between men *might* challenge

contemporary gender relations, but sex between “dudes” does not. Similar to the “bromance,” “dude sex” relies on symbolic relations to simultaneously challenge and reinforce systems of power and inequality. Though violating the “one-act rule” (Schilt and Westbrook 2009) of men’s homosexuality by participating in same-sex sex, these men simultaneously reinforce gendered and raced inequality. In fact, according to Ward’s research, engaging in same-sex sex is *proof* of their masculinity precisely because of their race and class position—a process Ward (2015) calls “hetero-exceptionalism.” Their identity projects are situated as having a better political and cultural “fit” with heterosexuality, relying on symbols and stereotypes of gendered and racialized performances of masculinity to authenticate their *heterosexual* masculine identities.

Some of men’s practices that initially appear to be feminist also perpetuate gender inequality even as they obscure it. Recent changes in the ideologies and practices of fathering may seem progressive—such as increasing levels of emotionality and time spent with children. But, upon closer investigation, they also often entrench gender inequality. The new fathering movement of the twentieth century, for instance, was not necessarily about challenging gender inequality in families, but about a particular *style* of men’s parenting (Messner 1993), that, as Stein (2005) argues, redraws boundaries around men’s heterosexuality and masculine authority. In her study of the Promise Keepers movement, Heath (2003) examines the ways that men embody “new fathering” by playing larger roles in their children’s lives and increasing their emotional availability while also enforcing gender inequality by espousing a “biblical” notion of “the family” in which women submit to their husbands (see also Donovan 1998).

Groups of evangelical Christian men exemplify the processes by which hybrid masculinities can be understood to fortify boundaries between groups even as they appear to challenge those boundaries (e.g., Diefendorf 2015; Wilkins 2009; Gerber 2015). For instance, Diefendorf’s (2015) analysis of young evangelical Christian men’s claims to sexual abstinence before marriage appear to be a fundamental departure from hegemonic configurations of masculinity, which emphasize sexual experience. She shows, however, that such claims are better understood as enabling these men to continue to collect on forms of gendered entitlement that have arguably been more successfully challenged outside of these groups. Thus, Diefendorf shows that rather than resisting hegemonic masculinity, this strategy is a hybrid configuration of masculinity that fortifies boundaries and systems of inequality between these men and “Other” men and between men and women in ways that work to these men’s collective (and continued) advantage.

While diverse boundary-blurring work is accomplished in many contemporary configurations of masculinity, much of this blurring is best understood as superficial. Within Connell’s framework, research on hybrid masculinities illustrates an extraordinary flexibility in symbolic and emotional relations. But this flexibility often works in ways that conceal the continued resilience of power relations. This makes the gender order appear to have transformed a great deal, when less has actually changed than these practices appear (and are sometimes used as evidence) to demonstrate.

Conclusion

Connell (1995) theorized something she calls “gender vertigo” as accompanying periods of change—the sense of unease as gendered personality structures and relations transform.³ It is associated with public challenges to cultural conceptualizations of masculinity and femininity and the experiences associated with charting new gender projects under shifting systems of opportunity and constraint—liberating for some, disorienting for others, and potentially infuriating for those who refuse to acknowledge change. As Connell writes,

The pattern of difference/dominance is so deeply embedded in culture, institutions and body-reflexive practices that it functions as a limit to the rights-based politics of reform. Beyond a certain point, the critique of dominance is rejected as an attack on difference—a project that risks gender vertigo and violence. (Connell 1995, 232)

Because crisis tendencies are a fundamental feature of the structure of gender relations, gender vertigo is a historically recycled set of anxieties that accompany transformation. Hybrid masculinities are gender projects that offer *some* men new tools to navigate the gender vertigo accompanying periods of crisis in gender relations. The hipster, the metrosexual, and the bromance, as well as other gendered configurations in this chapter, are gender strategies that accompany transformations. Our theorization of hybrid masculinities, however, situates them as more than this as well: hybrid masculinities are strategies with patterned consequences for groups of men who hold concentrated constellations of power and authority.

Recent changes—produced both by structural change and feminist critique and reform—have shed light on masculinity and gender privilege in historically unprecedented ways. Privilege works best when it is invisible, when it goes unrecognized by those who benefit the most. When the experiences of privilege are fundamentally altered, so too are the “legitimizing stories” that justify systems of gendered power and inequality. The concept of hybrid masculinities offers a framework within which we can better assess how privilege adapts to structural and sociopolitical change by highlighting these emergent strategies of action and legitimizing stories and strategies.

Research on hybrid masculinity suggests that we should be careful when assessing whether these transformations are best understood as challenges to systems of power and inequality or simply shifts in the ways those systems are perpetuated (e.g., Bridges 2014; Bridges and Pascoe 2014; Budgeon 2014). Legal scholar Reva Siegel (1996) refers to processes of social reproduction involving the appearance of social transformation that share some of the patterns we have identified here as “preservation-through-transformation.” Similarly, we suggest that it is critically important to separate an analysis of the motivations and the consequences of hybrid masculinities—recognizing patterned consequences even when individuals may be unaware of their participation or even their interests in reproducing existing structures of power and inequality.⁴ While the motivations behind hybrid configurations of masculinity may be to challenge inequality or explore pleasures men have been denied by stoic configurations of masculinity, research suggests three separate dimensions of hybrid masculinities that have the collective consequence of obscuring power and inequality. Indeed, rather than challenging inequality, they are better understood as what Kandiyoti (1988) referred to as “patriarchal bargains.”

Hybrid masculinity helps us recognize that meaningful changes in or successful challenges to systems of gendered power and inequality are more complex than they may at first appear. Considerations of what real (not simply stylistic) change will look like is an open question and must be answered with a framework capable of making sense of the elasticity of gender and sexual inequality.

Glossary of Key Terms

Discursive distancing—hybrid masculine practices that create symbolic space between privileged groups of men and hegemonic masculinity, enabling some men to frame themselves as outside of existing systems of privilege and inequality.

Fortifying boundaries—hybrid masculine practices that entrench and conceal systems of inequality in historically new ways, often along lines of race, gender, sexuality, and class.

Gender and sexual inequality—the organization of social relations through which heteronormative and patriarchal ideals become part of the structure of society, embedded in social institutions, interactions, identities, and culture.

Gender hegemony—the process by which gender inequality is justified through social structures, interactions, and institutions—a process that is continually transforming as it adapts to new historical circumstances, challenges, and social contexts.

Hegemonic masculinities—configurations of masculinity that symbolically organize inequalities among men and legitimate inequality between men and women.

Hybrid masculinity—the selective incorporation of identity elements typically associated with various marginalized and subordinated masculinities or femininities into privileged men’s gendered enactments and identities.

Strategic borrowing—hybrid masculine practices of cultural appropriation by which privileged groups claim ownership of cultural symbols associated with subordinated and marginalized social groups.

Notes

- 1 This type of intimacy—both emotional and physical—is not historically unique. A great deal of scholarship documents intimate relationships between men throughout U.S. history. See, for instance, E. Anthony Rotundo’s (1993) and John Ibson’s (2002) work on emotional and physical intimacy between men in the 19th and early 20th centuries as well as Jane Ward’s (2015) work, which documents same-sex intimacy as consistently part of heterosexual masculinity. What we are seeing today are contemporary expressions of a long-standing pattern of relationships among men rather than something historically unprecedented.
- 2 Subordinated and marginalized groups also incorporate elements associated with dominant groups as well. Consider Messerschmidt’s (1997) analysis of Malcolm X and his participation in a form of zoot-suit “hipster” masculinity among African American men in the 1930s and ‘40s in the United States as well as Nandy’s (1983) analysis of British colonialism in India. While they illustrate a process of hybridization of masculinity as well, African Americans and Indians are here motivated by very different concerns and operating under dramatically different constraints than the hybrid masculinities we analyze in this chapter. We are suggesting that this form of hybridization (involving dominant groups appropriating cultural elements of various Others) often works in ways that do not resist systems of inequality.
- 3 While “gender vertigo” is now primarily associated with Barbara Risman’s (2004) work on challenges to gender relations within the family, she borrows the concept from Connell’s theory.
- 4 Discussions of “men’s interests” are necessarily complex (e.g., Messner 2004). Connell discusses men’s “interests” in ways that do not necessarily demand conscious reflection or malicious intentions. As she writes, “Interests are formed in any structure of inequality, which necessarily defines groups that will gain and lose differently by sustaining or by changing the structure” (1995, 82). Our examination of hybrid masculinities considers them as working “in men’s interest” in a similar manner.

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Part V

Agendas for Theory

In this final section of the book, the chapters propose ideas for how gender theory should develop in the future. The first chapter, by Barbara J. Risman, Kristen Myers, and Ray Sin, argues for a theoretical “(re)turn” to gender as a social structure. Risman, Myers, and Sin examine the current neoliberal context that emphasizes how *individual choice* creates the danger of promoting *nonreflexive celebrations of diversity* while ignoring ongoing structural inequalities. Risman, Myers, and Sin call for viewing gender as a system of stratification while simultaneously resisting essentialist ideas—including the concept of *cisgender*—that create oversimplified umbrella categories. They urge prioritizing the deconstruction of gender structure as a precursor to creating a world characterized by greater equality in relation to gender and other categorical distinctions.

In the next chapter, Judith Lorber, in a return to her previous work on gender paradoxes, ponders the question of how—under what structural conditions—the emergence of multiple genders, and chosen gender displays, challenges structured social inequalities in workplaces, families, or other social institutions. Similar to what Bridges and Pascoe (in this volume) say about hybrid masculinities, *multiple genders*, Lorber warns, are not in and of themselves revolutionary. Lorber argues that the recent spate of multiple genders being hailed by some as a sign of degendering—a development that could undermine the current binary gender order—is in fact no such thing. Multiple genders not only fail to free people from gendered distinctions and norms, they help shore them up. Lorber favors the option of degendering the many realms of social life where we now place great emphasis on gender divisions.

Finally, the chapter by Mimi Schippers examines sexuality by arguing that the monogamous couple is a discursively constructed ideal and compulsory structure for sexual and emotional intimacy that simultaneously legitimates gender hegemony. Schippers examines polyamory, which refers to an intimate relationship—physical or emotional, or both—with more than one person at a time and to which all involved actively consent. She suggests that consensual nonmonogamies, such as polyamory, can develop new forms of intimate and sexual relationships by stressing gender egalitarianism, thereby becoming a fruitful area of empirical research and gender theory development. Schippers concludes that monogamy fosters unequal gender relations whereas polyamory has the potential to subvert inequality and promote egalitarian relations between women and men.

Limitations of the Neoliberal Turn in Gender Theory

(Re)Turning to Gender as a Social Structure

Barbara J. Risman, Kristen Myers, and Ray Sin

Choice feminism has co-opted feminist language in a way that takes the political out of the personal.

—Meghan Murphy, “Choice Feminism”

In 1987, Raewyn Connell published *Gender and Power*, introducing a new approach to understanding gender as *inequality*. She insisted on the importance of everyday practices and structural constraints, pushing us beyond individualistic approaches to gender. In this chapter we argue that advances first pioneered by Connell, the integration of structure and practice, highlighting the co-construction of individuals and society, are in danger of being reversed by a neoliberal¹ turn in gender theory.² To make this argument, we provide a brief history of gender scholarship. We then show how gender scholarship has recently veered away from concerns about sexism and inequality to focus on questions of identity and agentic gender performance as part of narrowing concerns to the individual, a shift at least compatible with a neoliberal turn.

We provide three different kinds of evidence for our concern: (1) recent research published in feminist journals that situates gender as individual identity or strategy with little attention to gender inequality (Bantjes and Nieuwoudt 2014; Mora 2012; Balogun 2012; Kim and Pike 2015; Gimlin 2013); (2) a recent focus on individual rights to choose pronouns and the identification of a new identity binary based on individual identity (“cis” as the opposite of trans) (Schilt and Westbrook 2009); and (3) the popularization of “born that way” rhetoric for gender, borrowed from the gay rights movement (Khan 2015). Using data from a collaborative research project studying Millennials,³ we show one limitation of the neoliberal turn toward identity in feminist writing: it cannot do justice to the complexity of young adult lives. We show that relying upon neoliberal concepts at the individual level of analysis hampers our understanding of the persistence of gender inequality even in the face of an increasing spectrum of gender performances. Finally, we conclude by suggesting a return to feminist scholarship that continues to celebrate diversity at the individual level while refocusing attention on feminist attempts to dismantle gender as a structure itself.

From Sex Roles to Stratification: A Brief History of Gender

During the heyday of functionalist sociology, only those writing about the family (e.g., Parsons and Bales 1955; Zelditch 1955) were interested in sex and gender. They theorized that sex roles should socialize girls for domesticity and boys for labor force participation and patriarchal fatherhood. Once the second wave of feminism crashed the gates of social science, women pointed out that gender is not about roles but primarily about inequality (England et al. 2007; Lorber 1994). Psychologists (e.g., Bem 1974, 1981; Spence, Helmreich, and Holahan 1975; Spence, Helmreich, and Stapp 1975) began to measure sex role attitudes using scales derived from old personality and employment tests (Terman and Miles 1936). Within a few years, however, it became clear that femininity and masculinity were not actually opposites

(Locksley and Colten 1979; Pedhazur and Tetenbaum 1979; Edwards and Ashworth 1977), and Bem (1981, 1993) reconceptualized gender in what was then a novel way: she posited that masculinity and femininity were two different personality dimensions distinct from bodies. This became the accepted understanding used by psychologists and sociologists alike.

Early feminist sociologists used sex role theory to show how gender socialization disadvantaged girls (Lever 1974; Stockard and Johnson 1980; Weitzman 1979) by socializing them into femininity as a personality trait, presuming gender training embedded societal norms deep inside of us. Psychologists and sociologists alike implied that the key to eradicating gender inequality was to raise a new generation without gender limits and to resocialize adults. Soon, however, feminist sociologists began to critique this approach that reduced gender to personality. Lopata and Thorne (1978) published a now classic article showing the functionalist presumptions underlying “sex role” explanations for differences between women and men: the very rhetorical use of the language of “role” requires conceptualizing a complementarity devoid of questions of power and privilege. Social scientists would never use the language of “race roles” to explain the differential opportunities and constraints of majority and minority members of a Western society. The language of “sex role” presumed a stability of behavior across the life cycle and gender patterns that are similar across class, sexuality, and race and ethnic groups. It became clear that gender was not only about socialized personalities and identities but that a more deeply sociological analysis was needed.

Two distinct sociological theoretical alternatives developed: an interactionist framework, “doing gender,” and a focus on how organizational structure shapes people, the new “structuralists.” The interactionist “doing gender” framework introduced by West and Zimmerman (1987) argued that gender is something we are held morally accountable to *perform*, something we do, not something we are. At the same time, a structural focus on workplace organizations was introduced by Kanter (1977) to explain inequality between women and men with organizational characteristics such as differential opportunity and tokenism. Apparent sex differences in leadership style represented women’s disadvantaged organizational placement, not their gendered personalities. Epstein (1988) supported this argument, suggesting that most of the differences between men and women were deceptive distinctions: if men and women were given the same opportunities and constraints, the differences between them would vanish. Much research ensued suggesting that male advantage remains even when men and women fill identical structural roles (Williams 1992). Purely social-structural variables cannot explain the power of gender.

Emerging during this period, Connell’s *Gender and Power* represented a shift in the paradigm of gender scholarship. Connell drew on historical cross-cultural research to argue that it was with the urban revolution and the development of bureaucratized state capitalism in Western Europe that gender inequality was institutionalized into the particular sexual division of labor we now recognize. The proliferation of trade and colonialism led to a global diffusion of colonial versions of gender, although always in conversation with local cultures. Connell concluded that gender is socially constructed, historically contingent, culturally specific, and about power. Connell offered a complex view of gender that included individual psychology, social structure, and the relationship between them. Connell’s work complicated feminist theorizing about gender, incorporating recursive models of structure and practice. Soon thereafter, Lorber (1994) suggested that gender difference itself was socially constructed, specifically as a legitimation for inequality. Similarly, Messerschmidt’s (1997, 2016) structured action theory also pushed the integrative envelope. He emphasized the “construction of sex, gender, and sexuality as situated social, interactional and embodied accomplishments” (2016, 37). Together these works shifted the ground: gender could no longer be understood entirely as psychology, nor entirely as structure (see Risman and Davis 2013 for a more detailed intellectual history of gender scholarship).

From the end of the 20th century onwards, the conceptualization of gender as a stratification system that exists outside of individual characteristics and varies along other axes of inequality became the new consensus (Lorber 1994; Martin 2004; Risman 1998, 2004; Collins 1990; Crenshaw 1989; Harris 1990; Ingraham 1994; Mohanty 2003; Nakano Glenn 1999). Theorists turned their attention to gender as an institutional structure of inequality across different levels of analysis (Lorber 1994; Martin 2003, 2004, 2006; Risman 1998, 2004; Acker 1990, 1992). Gender can be conceptualized as a social structure,

integrating social processes that occur at the individual, interactional, and macro levels of analysis without claiming a priori any more significant explanatory power (Risman 1998, 2004). The gender structure is dynamic and change in any aspect will reverberate throughout. Moreover, Connell's recognition of the global nature of the gender order has inspired scholars from different countries to understand how local gender structures interact with the gender orders from other countries, which, in turn, constitute a global gender regime (O'Connor, Orloff, and Shaver 1999; Walby 2004).

The Neoliberal Turn in Gender Scholarship: From Multilevel Stratification Systems to Choice Feminism's Essentialist Authentic Self

In the 21st century, there has been renewed attention to the individual level of analysis, to a concern with identities and the authenticity of gendered selves. While such issues are critically important, the increasing focus on diversity of gender identities and performances without linking them back to the social structure may have the unintended consequence of essentializing femininity and masculinity within the body. This returns us to a view of gender that is primarily about individuals, personalities, and selves and not a concern with societal stratification. The short history above provides evidence that this is not the first time that social science has struggled with gender essentialism. But this recent iteration seems to be distinct, spawned by the current influence of neoliberalism. Within a neoliberalist framework, attention is shifted to the "choice" and responsibility of individuals, with less attention to the governmental and other social-structural explanations for social life. While few feminist sociologists identify themselves as neoliberals, it seems as if there has been an unreflexive importation of neoliberal thought into the study of gender that is problematic both as an analytic strategy and as an effective collective feminist project to eradicate gender inequalities.

We provide three different kinds of evidence for our concern: (1) recent research published in feminist journals that highlight gender as individual identity or strategy with little attention to inequality; (2) the social construction of a new gender binary with the linguistic adoption of the term "cisgender" as an opposite of transgender and an array of new identity pronouns; and (3) a reliance upon "born that way" rhetoric, which requires essentialist presumptions.

Femininities and Masculinities

Much recent research focuses on the varieties of femininities and masculinities constructed by those in marginalized social groups, often providing thick description of masculinities and femininities of all varieties, with perfunctory concern for gender inequality or the processes of the social construction of gender itself (Bantjes and Nieuwoudt 2014; Mora 2012; Balogun 2012; Williams 2002; Gimlin 2013; Paechter 2007). For example, Kim and Pike (2015) critique the Father School movement in Korea for stigmatizing how Korean men "do gender" and for promoting Western hegemonic masculinity. But they do not much wrestle with how enactment of alternative masculinities might increase or decrease women's power in Korean families, the sexism women face in Korean society, or the homophobia faced by gender nonconforming men. Similarly, Gimlin (2013) examines narratives of women undergoing breast augmentation as aesthetic surgery and reports that the cultural narrative of desired femininity has shifted from authenticity to intervention and improvement. She suggests that the desire to improve oneself may signify empowerment and agency. What goes underexamined is that breast augmentation is another manifestation of the imposition of almost impossible standards of beauty upon women, standards that cannot be achieved without the burden of medical risks and exorbitant cost. Such burdens of beauty are primarily the work of women (and not men), and even among women such work further stratifies femininity by social class.

While description of the varieties of masculinities and femininities does help decenter the white middle class from the study of gender, what remains underanalyzed is how these varieties of "doing gender"

connect to inequality between the sexes, or even between the varieties of gender. Research on gender that focuses on cultural variations of femininities and masculinities, devoid of concern for the structure of inequality, is one kind of evidence of a global neoliberal worldview colonizing the study of gender.

Freedom from Old Binaries: Choosing New Pronouns and Identities and New Binaries

A second kind of evidence of an encroaching neoliberal focus on the individual is an increasing tendency to study the choices of individuals, while allowing social-structural analysis to recede into the murky background. Although sociologists have critiqued choice models for decades, there has been an increasing emphasis on choice in recent scholarship and activism (see Budgeon 2003; Baumgardner and Richards 2000). While choice may seem liberating and socially progressive, we agree with critics who have argued that it is a mistake to lose the forest while we study the trees (see Groenveld 2009; Murphy 2012; Zimmerman, McDermott, and Gould 2009). For example, the freedom for those who reject the binary of male/female (or men/women) to use new pronouns (e.g., *ze* and *hir*) may shake up the binary logic that presumes gender can only be about men and women. And yet the new ability to choose gender pronouns that evade the binary may ironically preserve the larger system of meaningful gender categories. When people resist gender categories because they are too limiting, pressure builds to shatter the stereotypes that bind. But if those most miserable within the categories as they now exist can opt out, then the pressure needed for stereotypes to lose power is lessened, leaving them intact. For those most oppressed, opting out eases the pain, which is important. Opting out itself can be revolutionary. If *everyone* were to opt out of gendered pronouns, the gender structure itself might crack down to its foundation. But does the recent proliferation of categories portend such an imminent collapse? We think not. Most people unreflexively inhabit the gendered binary, and those who opt out of male or female opt into a rebel category. Despite expanded choices for the few, the categories of women and men have remained intact, and stereotypes attached to gender continue to constrain the majority who remain identified as male or female. Rather than exploding gender categories altogether, choice allows liberty for some without attacking stereotypes or constraints for most others. Further, the rhetoric of cisgender makes intersex people invisible. There isn't an agreed-upon "sex category" to which intersex people "should" have been labeled at birth, as they are quite literally between the binary of sex categories (see Vilorio 2014).⁴ In fact, intersex scholars and activists point out that the sex categories themselves are social constructions used to oppress people who don't fit (Davis 2015; Fausto-Sterling 2012).

Neoliberal "choice" ideology has also trickled into feminist research on gender identities. One example of the individualist turn by gender scholars is the construction of the new category "cisgender," a term that refers to anyone who identifies with the gender that aligns with the sex they were assigned at birth (Schilt and Westbrook 2009). The term has recently come into popular use as more attention is given to people who transition from the sex assigned at birth to another sex (transgender), as well as those who reject the binary entirely (using identities such as genderqueer and agender). Indeed, the term has recently been added to the Oxford English Dictionary. Despite its popularity—or perhaps because of it—the rhetorical language of cisgender needs some deconstruction.

The earliest written record of using "cis" as a prefix related to gender can be traced to a German physician, Ernst Burchard, in a sexology textbook in 1914 (Williams 2013). Burchard used "cisvestitismus" to refer to human beings who dress in gender-normative clothing. But "cis" did not become popular for 80 years, until biologist Dana Leland Defosse used the term "cisgender" as a linguistic term within molecular biology. He used "cis" as a prefix to describe action from the same molecule, while "trans" refers to action from a different molecule. Organic chemistry uses the terms similarly (within and across). Cisgender as a term was only recently adopted by activists in the transgender rights movement to differentiate themselves from the majority (Enke 2012). In 2009, Schilt and Westbrook introduced cisgender to the sociological community as "individuals who have a match between the gender they were assigned at birth, their bodies, and their personal identity" (461).

This new terminology is useful in conversations about trans issues as it disrupts assumptions of gender normality. It acknowledges that trans people face especially pernicious, dehumanizing gender policing (see Schilt and Westbrook 2009; Westbrook and Schilt 2013; Schilt 2011). Yet the term cisgender also creates a

new binary, dividing those who are cisgender from those who are not. What it does not do is help us understand the increasing fluidity of bodies, identities, and performances in contemporary society. For example, children who identify as transgender may remain so identified for life, while others may not (Drescher and Pula 2014; Wallien and Cohen-Kettenis 2008). Some experience gender dysphoria only later in life. In Messerschmidt's 2016 book, *Masculinities in the Making*, some respondents are very clear that they have held a variety of identities and are open to the possibility of other identities in the future. How does a trans/cis divide help us or them chart new insights into gender fluidity, or ambiguity? What if the new binary itself simply adds another set of expectations on today's youth, instructing them to figure out who they "really" are and stay there?

The current concept of cisgender is limited in three major ways. First, the cis-trans language introduces yet another binary, oversimplifying gender complexity for all people, including ignoring those actually born intersex. Second, the concept presumes a certain gender essentialism, at least for those who are not trans. Third, and perhaps most problematic, is that this new language leaves the other gender inequality unmarked: between men and women (whether they are those assigned the category at birth or not), and between those who conform to gender stereotypes and those who do not. While the point of this new binary is to underscore that cisgender people are privileged, and transgender people are not, the articulation of that privilege with male privilege and gender conformity is often left unexplored (for an exception, see Schilt 2011).

It is very clear that the language of cisgender and the new gender binary is useful for transgender activism. The very existence of a rhetoric for "marking" what Schilt and Westbrook (2009) refer to as "gender normals" highlights the argument that neither group is more normal than the other. Both cis and trans people need to be identified by an identity label for trans activism. What is less clear is whether such a new binary is useful for social science.

"Born That Way" Rhetoric: From Sexual to Gender Identities

In a neoliberal framework, where individual choice and freedom are at the center of attention, conflicts among social scientists can indeed erupt. We see this happening in research on sexual orientation and political activism. Khan (2015) argues that while the "born this way" explanation for lesbian and gay identities has been effective in the marriage equality movement, it obfuscates the strong social science that has shown that sexuality is culturally variable and that homosexuality as an identity is a modern invention. Extending this same logic to gender, Khan contrasts basic sociological evidence about gender as socially constructed with the strongly held opinions of those who believe that masculinity or femininity is their only biologically "authentic" self. That belief can be as strongly held by those assigned male at birth and by transmen, or by those assigned female at birth and by transwomen. And, yet, much research in social science shows that biological determinants explain a small variance of gendered responses and identities (Cohen-Bendahan, van de Beek, and Berenbaum, 2005; Davis and Risman 2014; Jordan-Young 2010). The meanings attached to gender and the ways gender is manifested are culturally shaped, historically contingent, and variable. Still, gender (like sexuality) is often experienced as a deeply essential authentic core self. To the extent that we uncritically accept the essential need to be masculine or feminine as biologically "authentic," we support individuals' right to self-determination. But to do so as social scientists requires us to ignore what is at the moment the state of the art social scientific evidence. We agree with Khan (and also see D'Emilio 2002) that most social scientists remained silent regarding their knowledge about sexual plasticity because of the political efficacy in doing so. To remain silent in a political movement may be efficacious, but social scientists have not remained silent about the social construction of sexual identities within the social scientific community. We fear the silencing of social science in the face of the rhetoric of a new essentialist gender binary (cis/trans). Surely there are better ways to affirm and support the rights of transgender and genderqueer people without creating a binary that ignores the variation in gendered selves among the many who are not transgender and challenges the theoretical power of the social construction of gender. To concretely illustrate the problem of narrowing attention to gender identity once again, we turn to an overview of a study we have conducted of U.S. Millennial youth.

Millennials and the Gender Structure: The Limitations of Neoliberal Conceptualizations of Gender

In order to explain the empirical limitations of neoliberal frameworks on our understanding of gender complexity, we use data from a research project on which we collaborated. In this project, we collected 116 interviews with mostly working class minority Chicagoland Millennials. The sample was also gender diverse, with over 15 percent respondents who were genderqueer or trans. Their stories illustrate how focusing on individual identity, choice, and the rhetoric of cisgender would create far more confusion than clarification.

In analyzing our data, if we were to apply the cis/trans binary to our sample, we would be unable to understand the experiences of all of our subjects. Cis people are not at all a homogenous, monolithic group. They do not share some attribute that provides them a common privilege. Too broad an array of people are currently defined as cis: effeminate men, butch women, tough guys, and feminine ladies. Men and women who do not conform to gender stereotypes may challenge the gender structure even as they claim a gender category that aligns with their assigned sex. For example, we talked to a self-identified butch lesbian woman who had always felt constrained by gender norms and oppressed by her body. Once she had her breasts removed, she was at peace with being female and was distressed when panhandlers addressed her as “sir.” Why is it helpful to label this woman as cisgender? Her struggles are ignored if we lump her into this amorphous category.

Similarly, the cis/trans dichotomy also has the unintended consequence of essentializing the trans community as undifferentiated. Some trans people seek to pass, while others want to disrupt gender categories altogether. We found the stories told by transgender respondents who were in transition and wanted very much to pass as “the opposite sex” were very different from the transgender respondents who were rebels against the gender structure and were comfortable being publicly and openly identified as transwomen or transmen. Both were quite distinct from those who held a genderqueer identity, or were neither male nor female identified. The Millennials who opted for a genderqueer identity and who wanted to smash the binary are also sometimes categorized within the broad “trans” label in that they rejected the sex category assigned at birth. Our genderqueer respondents were quite different from the transgender ones, however, as they reported far less childhood trauma and were far more political in their conceptualization of gender politics.

In order to apply the cis/trans lens to our sample, we would be forced to categorize our subjects as either cis or trans. How do we determine this? Categorizing people into the cis/trans dichotomy involves exploring how they align their “true selves” with their gender performances. Assuming that people have an essential gendered nature flies in the face of theoretical insights of the past four decades, and it collapses the complexity that Connell herself helped us to understand. A focus on people’s true selves pushes us backward toward a biological essentialism that research does not support. For example, gender nonconforming respondents talked very openly about having held a variety of gender identities. A self-identified genderqueer female had previously identified as a butch lesbian, and then as a transboy. She wanted us to know that her gender was a journey, and she did not know where it might lead. But she was very open to yet another identity still in the future. The creation of a category of “cis” versus “trans” presumes a stability that simply does not exist, at least not for all of our respondents. And how can it be applied to the intersex? Are intersex people who align their gender identity with the sex category that was imposed by their medical doctors during infancy cisgender (see Costello 2015)?⁵

And finally, were we to rely on a neoliberal analytical framework, we would fail to examine the structural consequences of gender. The gender structure bifurcates and stratifies people as women and men regardless of whether or not they self-identify as such. For example, Pfeffer (2014) writes about how misrecognition of transmen and their partners as normatively heterosexual renders their queer identities invisible. Schilt (2011) shows that male privilege is accorded to transmen who pass as men but not to those who do not. Perhaps transmen have more in common—in the workplace—with hegemonic men who do gender in a socially valuable way than with others who display gender nonconformity, even if their

gender performance doesn't match their sex assigned at birth. In our research, the young men who broke gender norms told gut-wrenching stories about being bullied by other boys, and about being sometimes stigmatized by their own families. Transgender Millennials told such stories but so did boys, gay and straight, who didn't "man up," who rejected team sports for fashion interests, or wanted the freedom to wear bright colors and makeup. Stigma is experienced by those who reject gender-normative lives, whether they are transgender, genderqueer, effeminate men, butch women, or anyone else. Patriarchal dividends are awarded to those who subscribe to gender-normative behavior. We must use theoretical lenses that enable us to critique the gender structure. Despite the promise of personal freedom, the ability to choose your gender, from an increasing array of possibilities, as your authentic gender does not free one from gender inequality.

Ongoing and Future Debates: Where Should We Go from Here?

The landscape of gender identities is growing ever more complicated. Some people enjoy "doing gender," especially the aspects that are not inherently stratification markers, such as makeup, pumping iron, and fashion. Others strongly identify with gender categories distinct from sex assignment at birth, and, for them, gender is a source of liberation from imprisonment in bodies that do not match their identities. In our technologically sophisticated society, bodies seem more malleable than selves. There are also now genderqueer or agender identity people who deny the binary of male/female and occupy the space between the categories. We have no longitudinal data to know if previous generations had equal numbers of gender nonconformists hidden in closets or whether this era allows more exploration of all facets of the self. But we can hypothesize that the cracks in our gender structure (language first offered by Connell and now a part of our shared theoretical language) have allowed feminist and queer theories to develop, and with those theories the very possibility of imagining new ways to live across and between the binary has emerged.

Research is needed to even hazard a guess whether the defiance of assigned gender categories, identities, and statuses reflects dissatisfaction with the gender structure as we know it or simply dissatisfaction with one's own gendered expectations. We see far more divorce in modern societies than in more traditional ones, but that does not mean that a divorcing spouse rejects marriage as an institution, only that they don't like the particular person to whom they are married at the moment. Perhaps for some trans people, gender is entirely a personal issue, and the gender structure ceases to feel oppressive once they change categories. In our study of Millennials, however, some transgender and genderqueer youth reject the notion that there should be gender categories and see their choices in opposition to a binary gender structure. Perhaps the category of transgender is insufficient for transgender men and women and genderqueer people to coexist within it. Identity categories are always socially constructed, contested, and historically contingent, and our research simply illustrates that this is also true for our current crop of gender identities.

In this chapter, we have argued that there has been a neoliberal turn in gender scholarship. This neoliberal turn is evidenced by all the scholarly attention to individual identities without clear analysis of the relationship between individuals and the social structure, and the relationship between them. Attention must still be paid to gender inequality across sex categories and to inequality between gender identities. It is important to link a focus on the diversity of gender identities and performances back to the gender structure. If we focus only on identities and individuals' right to name their own gender, we risk the unintended consequence of essentializing femininity and masculinity within the body. This returns us to a view of gender that is primarily about individuals and not about stratification. Within a neoliberal framework, attention is narrowed to the "choice" of individuals with less attention to the governmental and other social-structural explanations for social life. Neoliberalism is in the intellectual air we breathe in the 21st century. In a world with increasingly fewer unions or pensions or stable employment contracts, the individual managing his or her own trajectory has become routine. Individuals are responsible for choosing everything from religious denominations to health care plans to identities. We suggest this individualist focus has been imported into the study of gender. This is problematic both as an analytic strategy and for a collective feminist project to eradicate gender inequalities.

We can envision two possible future scenarios as a result of more gender categories. First, we foresee that those who now “choose” to use male- or female-identified pronouns that align with the sex ascribed to them at birth will be under more pressure to behave in stereotypically masculine or feminine ways. If male, to be tough and sturdy, agentic, and emotionally repressed, and, if female, to be empathetic, nurturing, and avoid being “bossy.” Those who “choose” new gender-neutral pronouns are freed to be who they want to be. In such a scenario, choosing gender-alternative pronouns creates comfort and a sense of belonging for those who do so. That is useful, but it is far less radical a solution to gender inequality than a challenge to the very gender expectations attached to categories themselves. The need to focus on structural inequality and the social construction of gendered categories may recede if those most oppressed by them have a personal choice to opt out. A second possible scenario, and our advice to activists, is to use the proliferation of gender identities to critique the need for categories themselves. Bem (1995) once suggested that the explosion of sexual identities would eventually lead us to realize that sexuality needn’t be organized by types of people at all, but by relationships between them. So, too, an explosion of gender identities should lead to questioning whether we need gender categories and their attendant stereotypes at all.

What will the future bring? Nothing is inevitable because, as Connell notes, the present moment “is not a culmination but a point of choice” (279). We worry that interactional expectations, cultural ideology, and institutional constraints may become nearly invisible in a neoliberal framework that orients us entirely to the politics of individual choice. If gender is reduced to a quest for authentic identity among individuals, we have reverted to an essentialist belief about “real” gender essence, even if we expand the conversation to include people whose “real” gender does not match their assigned sex.

The need for feminist social action is as necessary as ever. Gender inequality between women and men, and within gender categories, is still rampant. We believe the most radical way forward is to destabilize the gender structure: to dismantle the binary categories upon which the gender structure is based. Gender transgressions of all sorts can push toward this goal: genderqueer youth destabilize taken-for-granted presumptions when they demand gender-neutral pronouns. Transgender community members demanding equality under the law and in civil society destabilize the presumption that gender must conform to biological bodies. Male caretakers and female leaders smash stereotypes as well. While expanding the list of categories that we use to denote gender *may* help to disrupt the gender structure, it cannot do so if those categories simply defuse tension for the most oppressed, leaving the categories themselves unchallenged. We cannot achieve a feminist utopia without more critical research on sexism and gender as a social structure. We have hardly moved beyond the paradox of gender (Lorber 1994). We must continue to make gender inequality visible before we can dismantle it. While we support each individual’s right to live with an authentic identity, we suggest that no one is truly free to do so as long as gender as a social structure persists.

It is imperative that gender scholars continue to study, and support, those who reject gender norms, who change their sex category, and genderqueers who reject binary categories entirely. But we cannot do so with a focus only on individual-level identity politics. As feminist analysts, we must understand gender rebellion as a response to a repressive gender structure, not merely a desire to live authentically according to an essential presocial self. We hope this is a transitional moment in history, where new categories help explode the expectations attached to sex categories, so that masculinity and femininity have little social meaning, and are not attached to male or female bodies, or to the categories of man and woman. As such, we can create a bridge to a future with a less oppressive gender structure.

With this chapter, we have attempted to foster a respectful dialogue among gender scholars with different perspectives but who share the feminist goal that everyone should have freedom to live authentic lives within, beyond, or between gender categories. We are committed to a feminist vision of a society with gender equality. As long as people assigned as female at birth face differential expectations compared to those labeled male at birth, our society will remain gender stratified with inequality embodied at the individual level, policed at the interactional level, and accepted as cultural logic and official policy at the

macro level. Only when the sex category assigned at birth has no more power than the color of one's eyes (Okin 1989) will we have gender equality. Perhaps when that time comes, gender can be reconstituted without inequality. But why would anyone then want to do so?

Notes

- 1 There is no one definition of neoliberalism. On a broad conceptual level, neoliberal ideology is the injection of market principles into all aspects of society and its attendant implications for geopolitics across nations, local domestic politics, and the individual. In this chapter, we focus on the implications of neoliberalism on the individual when it comes to gender. As Peters (2001) argues, neoliberalism on the individual level represents a shift toward individualizing social problems as personal responsibilities and choices. Hence solutions to social problems such as gender inequality are now placed on self-help, self-empowerment, and self-reliance.
- 2 Barbara J. Risman thanks both the University of Illinois at Chicago and the Center for Advanced Study in the Behavioral Sciences at Stanford for support during a sabbatical year in 2015–16 during which this article was written.
- 3 Millennials are a demographic cohort. While there are no precise agreed-upon dates, they range from those born in the early 1980s until the end of the 20th century. The label implies that they came of age in this new millennium.
- 4 See www.hidaviloria.com.
- 5 See trans-fusion.blogspot.com.

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Paradoxes of Gender Redux

Multiple Genders and the Persistence of the Binary

Judith Lorber

I have been out as an agender, or genderless, person for about a year now. To me, this simply means having the freedom to exist as a person without being confined by the limits of the western gender binary. . . . People don't know what to make of me when they see me, because they feel my features contradict one another. They see no room for the curve of my hips to coexist with my facial hair; they desperately want me to be someone they can easily categorise. My existence causes people to question everything they have been taught about gender, which in turn inspires them to question what they know about themselves, and that scares them. Strangers are often desperate to figure out what genitalia I have.

—Tyler Ford, “My Life without Gender”

Within the space of two weeks in 2014, the *New York Times* published several pieces on multiple genders. One was on the fiftysome choices of gender identity for Facebook users (Ball 2014; Herbenick and Baldwin 2014). These could be bigender, agender, gender fluid, variant, questioning, queer, transman, transwoman, intersex, neutrois, two-spirit, and variations of each. Another article reported that Australia's High Court has allowed someone to register their gender officially as “nonspecific” (Baird 2014) and another that India's Supreme Court had recognized transgender as a third gender (Varma and Najar 2014). In 2013, Germany allowed parents of intersexed babies to register them as “indeterminate” (Nandi 2013). “Queer,” once a radical identity, has almost become the new normal (Wortham 2016). These are twenty-first-century iterations of going beyond the binary, the strict division of people into two and only two sexes or genders, a subject I've been exploring for twenty years (Lorber 1996, 2001). They are indicators of multiple personal genders and much more limited official third genders.

Despite the blurring of boundaries in chosen gender identities, there does not seem to be very much actual, lived erasure of gender displays. At an art exhibit in New York City not long ago, I was struck by the way the gender of the members of the avant-garde crowd was clearly identifiable as “man” or “woman.” There were no “nonspecifics,” let alone fifty varieties of gender.

Theoretically, the erosion of gender boundaries should undercut gendered power inequalities and sustain the thrust toward a gender-equal social order. In the social construction conceptualization of gender, processes and practices (“doing gender”) that are repeated and ritualized congeal into a structure that encourages further repetition of gendered practices (Butler 2004; Lorber 2008; West and Zimmerman 1987). These practices create the differences between women and men that justify the inequities of power and privilege embedded in gender regimes. Personally chosen genders should affect the interactive processes that sustain social action and that ultimately influence practices in workplaces, families, and other social institutions. But the multiplicity of genders that supposedly has undermined the gender binary in Western cultures does not seem to have a positive interactive or structural effect. Rather, gender-variant appearances incur more opprobrium and violence than those experienced by transgendered people (Harrison, Grant, and Herman 2011–12; Vaid-Menon 2015). The most benign result seems to be the increasingly common designation of single-use bathrooms as M/F (Smith 2015) but not the spread of gender-neutral multiple-use facilities (Molotch and Norén 2010).

The gender paradox I explored over twenty years ago focused on the rhetoric of gender equality made meaningless by a total system that rendered women unequal and exploited (Lorber 1994). Today's gender paradox is a rhetoric of gender multiplicity made meaningless by a continuing system of bigendered social structures that support continued gender inequality. Underneath the seeming erasure of a rigid gender binary and its discriminatory norms and expectations lurks the persistence of men's power and privilege (Connell and Messerschmidt 2005; Kent 2015).

The revolutionary acceptance of homosexual and transgender women and men has ended there—with acceptance but without structural change (Walters 2014). Gays, lesbians, and transgendered people fit right into the gender binary. Homosexuality does not seem to diminish masculinity anymore (Browne 2014). Lesbians are women first and foremost; indeed, lesbianism has been defined as a continuum of women's emotional gamut (Rich 1980). Transgender men are coached in masculinity (Schilt 2011) and transgender women in femininity (Rogers 1992); both seek to legitimize bureaucratically and legally their chosen gender as man or woman (Currah, Juang, and Minter 2006). In short, what seems to be revolutionary—valorization of coming out as homosexual, same-sex marriage, and open transgender identity—has not changed the structure of binary gender regimes. Insidiously, these gender regimes, even those that are seemingly the most gender-equal in resource distribution, political power, and social privileges, such as those of Scandinavia, often still favor men (Borchorst 2009; Borchorst and Siim 2008).

The problem is that the popular concept of gender currently is what you believe you are and how you present yourself. It's not relational, social, structural, or institutional, but purely personal. Throwing gender back into personal identity ignores what feminists have learned about state gender regimes and the bureaucratic and legal imposition of binary categories. It also ignores the interactional and behavioral norms and expectations that validate personal gender identities. Another throwback is the resurgence of supposedly scientific support for male-female hardwiring of the brain and the subsequent behavior of immutably patterned children and adults that is often invoked to justify the choice of gender identity and sexuality (Jordan-Young 2011).

Where is the gender revolution feminists sought? Where is the thrust for a weakening of gender's pervasiveness? Interpersonally, "woman" and "man" are still enacted and maintained, and gender inequality persists.

How Could Multiple Gendering Have a Structural Effect?

At the end of *Gender and Power*, Raewyn Connell proposes two scenarios for change: abolition of gender and playing with gender (1987, 286–293). Abolition of gender could be accomplished by relegating sex differences to physical procreation, so that they are not "a cosmic division or a social fate" (287). Sexual and emotional binaries would be irrelevant, and masculinity and femininity would be meaningless. Instead, we would have "open-ended variety." That sounds like multiple gendering. Connell says that, without gender, it would be a "seriously impoverished" world (288). A more palatable alternative would be playing with gender and sexuality, or, as we would put it today, queering them: "Elements of sexual character, gender practice or sexual ideology are often disconnected and recombined for enjoyment, erotic tension, subversion or convenience" (289). That also sounds like multiple gendering.

Let's consider multiple gendering as an opening wedge of gender change, a precursor to abolishing gender as a binary social institution. Consistent presentation of self as not specifically a man or a woman would affect interaction, which should then in turn affect gender as a building block of social structure. There have been many real-life instances of parents raising a Baby X (Green and Friedman 2013) and many accounts of the liminal phases of gender transitioning, when the person is not easily identifiable as a man or a woman (Ames 2005). Despite the current climate of transgender acceptance, blurred gender identities seem to generate hostility and discomfort, especially in body-germane settings, such as bathrooms (Cavanagh 2010).

I am going to infer some possible effects of nonbinary gendering from research on sexual borderlands (Callis 2014), Patricia Hill Collins's analysis of how Black women could become empowered (2000,

275–290), Cecilia Ridgeway’s discussion of a possible end to the pervasive gender frame (2011, 190–200), and consequences of nongendered bathrooms (Cavanagh 2010; Molotch and Norén 2010).

Borderlands

Those who are not conventionally gendered live in a borderland between men and women. Drawing on the borderlands theory of Gloria Anzuldúa (1987) and the work of Pablo Vila (2000), April Scarlette Callis (2014) explored how people sexually identifying as bisexual, pansexual, queer, and other nonbinaries inhabit the borderland between heterosexuality and homosexuality. Callis notes that, theoretically, “borderlands simultaneously develop their own cultures while challenging hegemonic ideology” (68). By this analogy, those who inhabit sexual borderlands should be creating new forms of being sexual and eventually open a space for an institutionalized “third sexuality.” What she found was the other way around: the sexual borderland was created by the structures of heterosexuality and homosexuality. The thirty-seven people with nonbinary sexualities she interviewed “used 21 different terms or phrases in multiple combinations to label their sexual identities. Despite the wide array of labels used, all of these identities were formed as a reaction to the binary of heterosexual/homosexual, and each moved within and beyond this binary” (78).

Multiple genders, I would argue, exist in a borderland similarly constrained by a powerful binary frame. Like those with nonbinary sexualities, those who invoke nonstandard gender identities have not developed a shared identity or culture. They include transpeople who alter their bodies in order to transition and live as women or men, those with intersexed bodies who want a third gender or X identity, and those with the bodies they were born with who have adopted alternative gender identities. They are too heterogenous and too fragmented to challenge the binary hegemony. Transpeople may support the gender binary, but do people who don’t want to be tied down to hegemonic labels of “man,” “woman,” “male,” “female” want to destroy it? It is oppressive and it does deprive those who live outside the heteronormative sexual and gender binary of rights, resources, and social power. Transgendered and intersexual people have generated substantial activism for rights specific to their physical and social situations, but the advocates of multiple gendering have not produced a unified standpoint or a revolutionary politics that might more generally undermine binary gendering.

The Politics of Empowerment

Hill Collins (2000, 274) asks, “But how does one develop a politics of empowerment without understanding how power is organized and operates?” Those invoking multiple genders may see themselves as rebels, but are they drawing on knowledge of the politics of empowerment to make real change? According to Hill Collins,

Whether viewed through the lens of a single system of power or through that of intersecting oppressions, any particular matrix of domination is organized via four interrelated domains of power, namely, the structural, disciplinary, hegemonic, and interpersonal domains. . . . The structural domain organizes oppression, whereas the disciplinary domain manages it. The hegemonic domain justifies oppression, and the interpersonal domain influences everyday lived experience and the individual consciousness that ensues. (2000, 276)

Let’s take each domain in turn to see how multiple gendering could be empowered to change it.

Multiple gendering could affect the structure of the gender binary if there were a concerted effort to either abolish bureaucratic gender identities or to legally and medically recognize the range of sexed bodies. Despite the biological challenges of intersexed anatomies and anomalous hormonal and chromosomal development, each body is forced into a procrustean legal gender identity. Ambiguous infantile genitalia are surgically altered to look “normal” soon after birth (Dreger 1998; Kessler 1998).

Anomalies continuously plague gender categorization in sports, with forced body changes rather than challenges to the intensely gendered structure of this powerful and pervasive institution (Dreger 2009; Karkazis and Jordan-Young 2014).

Hill Collins (2000) notes the conflicts of “outsiders within,” those who have been able to move into positions of power in dominant institutions, but who are in danger of co-optation to maintain their positions and who therefore do not use their different perspectives to alter policies and practices. Transgendered people and homosexuals have made their identities visible and have promulgated nondiscriminatory laws, legal identity change, and marriage equality, but just adopting a variant gender identity does not seem consequential or revolutionary. It seems to be a matter of individual consciousness—not the end point of a process of change, but the beginning. However, after consciousness of the strictures of the two-gender social structure and the adoption of a gender-variant personal identity, there does not seem to be a path of rebellion. The two areas that should get shaken up by the open invocation and adoption of nonbinary gender identities are interpersonal interaction and hegemonic thinking about gender. Are they?

The Gender Frame

Ridgeway (2011, 190–192) argues that to make gender less powerful as a frame for most interaction, people would have to stop automatically categorizing everyone as a man or a woman. She feels this is highly unlikely since it creates too much social confusion and even anxiety in others because it “challenges the stability and validity of their own identity as a man or woman” (191). Of course, if others’ gender identity was irrelevant to the interaction, then no one’s gender would be of consequence. For that to happen, gender status beliefs and relevance would have to alter substantially (193).

If men did more of women’s work and women more of men’s work both in the workforce and at home, Ridgeway argues, conventional gender beliefs would be challenged and gradually made less relevant. In actuality, what has happened is that when men do what has been conventionally seen as “women’s work,” such as nursing or child care, it is reframed in gendered ways: men in nursing do more physical work or get rapidly promoted to administrative positions, and they do child care in masculine ways—roughhousing, sports, physical play. Women doing men’s work, such as military combat, going into space, and ruling countries, are seen as remarkable innovators, but not the norm. Women now dominate in previously masculine professions, such as Western medicine, and have changed curricula and ways of practice, turning it into women’s work, but men still predominate in the more lucrative specialties—surgery, neurology, and sports medicine. Thus, gendered cultural overlays persist, even as practices have shifted.

Bathrooms: Confronting the Material Binary

One of the arenas where gender-variant people have interacted with the conventionally gendered is multiuse bathrooms. The confrontations do not augur well for cultural change.

The demand for gender-neutral single-use bathrooms and then multiple-use bathrooms used to come from feminist women tired of waiting in long lines while men’s rooms were empty. It was an integral part of the fight for gender equality (Edwards and McKie 1996; Molotch 1988). The current demand is coming from people who are gender-variant as well as from women (Brown 2005; Weiner 2015). In the United States, the demands for gender-neutral bathrooms are still seen as so radical as to continue to warrant public comment (Chemaly 2015; Smith 2015) and legal battles (Liptak 2016; Suk Gersen 2016).

Gender-variant users of multiple-use bathrooms visibly confront the binary gender social order. They violate what is to many people the psychological and biological immutability of their own sex and gender identity. In *Queering Bathrooms*, Sheila L. Cavanagh (2010) explored the shocked responses to the use of conventional bathrooms by people whose gender appearance is problematic or ambiguous. She suggests that being in a bathroom with someone of a seemingly different gender disrupts the psyche’s carefully developed gender identity, achieved in great part through toilet training. The confrontation challenges the expectation that everyone is the same gender since they were born and have bodies congruent with gender

appearance. Cavanagh interviewed 100 mostly white, able-bodied, middle-to-upper-class graduate students and others aged 18–59 who identified as transsexual or transgender, as gender queer, and as gay, lesbian, and bisexual. Three self-identified as intersex. Their experiences were with multiuse Western bathrooms. Many were activists, so they were able to analyze the reaction to their bathroom use. They reported double takes, verbal challenges, the calling of security guards, and even arrests.

Thus, conventional users of gendered bathrooms uphold the binary and the clear segregation of women and men in certain public spaces. Safety is invoked, although women would be safer in bathrooms where there are several of each gender. The comfort of being with “one’s own” in a private space is also an issue. There is no official mandate for nongendered, multiuse bathrooms, the way legal racial desegregation and laws governing access for the disabled altered bathroom use. In “On Not Making History,” Harvey Molotch (2010) described a unisex bathroom that never got built at New York University’s new facilities for a Department of Social and Cultural Analysis. He says, “It was a lost opportunity to inscribe social change into architectural form and to use form to facilitate intellectual growth” (264). But it didn’t have enough supporters who were willing to fight for it.

The Paradox of Multiple Genders

The idea of multiple sexualities and multiple genders is not a twenty-first century invention. Early in the last century, Magnus Hirschfeld argued for sexual diversity. According to Alex Ross (2015), reviewing Robert Beachy’s *Gay Berlin: Birthplace of a Modern Identity* (2014) in the *New Yorker*:

The good doctor . . . preached the gorgeousness of difference, of deviations from the norm. From the beginning, he insisted on the idiosyncrasy of sexual identity, resisting any attempt to press men and women into fixed categories. To Hirschfeld, gender was an unstable, fluctuating entity; the male and the female were “abstractions, invented extremes.” He once calculated that there were 43,046,721 possible combinations of sexual characteristics, then indicated that the number was probably too small. (77)

But the gay rights movement, then and now, had to present a unified face to fight for an end to stigmatization and discrimination.

The politics of identity demand that you know who is “us” and who is “them.” As William Connolly says in *Identity/Difference*, “Identity requires difference in order to be, and it conveys difference into otherness in order to secure its own self-certainty” (1991, 94). Joan Wallach Scott calls it an inevitable feminist paradox that to fight to erase the effects of sex differences, you have to invoke them:

To the extent that it acted for “women,” feminism produced the “sexual difference” it sought to eliminate. This paradox—the need both to accept *and* to refuse “sexual difference”—was the constitutive condition of feminism as a political movement throughout its history. (Scott 1996, 3–4)

Sometimes differences need to be created to make a place for women. Radical feminists in particular valorized women’s ways—caring, emotionality—as equal to if not superior to men’s focus on rationality, objectivity, and physical violence. Maya Maor (2015) found an example of such a practice in martial arts, where women teachers create their own more relational, emotional, and less brutal style of karate and taekwon do to make themselves visible.

Another paradox in the politics of identity is that acceptance and integration often produce what Urvashi Vaid (1995) calls virtual equality, the erasure of differences without changes in the social structure that

make it possible to live differently. For the group, however, the marks of differentness may help their members identify one another as sources of help. As Suzanna Danuta Walters says of the gay and lesbian community in the United States, “One of the positive ‘fallouts’ of discrimination is the forging of community and the development of a concern for others, activism, a culture of responsibility. The response to AIDS is only one example” (2001, 19). However, Jane Ward’s research (2004) on an AIDS service organization found that Latina lesbian women felt their health-care needs were neglected because most of the money went to gay Latino men. Obviously, differences must be bracketed off for some political actions and invoked when it is politically necessary to counter invisibility.

The question is, can “multiple gender” be a unified identity around which to rally to make structural change? What do those espousing multiple gender identities want? Just the right to call themselves a nonbinary name? To act it out? To legalize it? The first is a matter of personal identity; the second would challenge conventional face-to-face interaction; the third would disrupt the structure of the gender binary. The first and second goals don’t need political unification; the third does. It would, ironically, establish a new boundary—between those who categorize by gender and those who do not (once a joke of bathroom identification with a long history).

Those who queer the gender and sexuality binaries rebel against the strictures of two and only two oppositional and fixed categories (Beemyn and Eliason 1996; Castro-Varela, Dhawan, and Engel 2011; Elliot 2010). They construct ambiguities and blur borders, but they haven’t undermined the structural or interactional foundations of gender as a binary institution. Queer theory has argued that change will come when there are so many sexualities and genders that one cannot be played against the other as normal and deviant, valued and stigmatized.

The problem is that multiple gender identities exist within the gender binary and are informed by it. Multiple genders have not been frequently used in face-to-face interaction, although they may be invoked on the Internet and in bathroom use. To make structural change, people with various nonbinary gender identifications would have to perform their genders of choice openly, confront conventional others in interaction, coalesce into a unified force, bring new knowledge to bear on gender issues, and insist on bureaucratic and legal recognition.

The paradox of multiple gendering is that a politics of identity demands clear boundaries of “us” and “them.” There may be coalitions and eventual erasure of the boundaries, but, for the purposes of resistance and rebellion, those insisting on multiple genders would be in the paradoxical position of establishing a new gender category.

Multiple Genders and Gender Equality

A further question is whether the current blurring of gender identities has the potential of enhancing gender equality. If we argue that gender as an institution is built on the construction of a gender binary, and that evident differences between the genders allow for the subsequent hegemony of men and masculinity and the exploitation of women’s paid work and unpaid domestic labor and sexuality, then the blurring of the binary should lead to greater equality. If we can’t tell or don’t remark on gender in face-to-face interaction, women and men should be social equals. I have argued that with that goal in mind, everyone should practice degendering—consciously act and talk and behave as if everyone had no gender (Lorber 2000, 2005). It should be everyone’s revolution, not just those who deliberately queer gender. But it needs legal and bureaucratic degendering as well, as in the gender-equal countries, where men and women are comparably educated, work in comparable occupations and professions for equal pay, have comparable political power, and share responsibility for the care of children. In short, if gender is irrelevant, not just multiple, then gender equality should follow.

This argument is testable. My hypothesis is that the more gender boundaries are blurred in attitudes, interaction, and identity, the greater the actual gender equality. The World Economic Forum’s Global Gender Gap Index measures gender equality in the relative gaps between women and men in health, education, economy, and politics. According to the 2015 Global Gender Gap report, educational attainment

and health and survival are close to parity globally—women and men share equally in whatever resources are available in a country. The economic participation and opportunity gender gap closed by 59 percent in the last decade but the political empowerment gap closed by only 23 percent (World Economic Forum 2015). Ranked on a combined index where gender-equal parity is 1, the highest scoring countries in 2015 were Iceland (0.881), Norway and Finland (0.850), Sweden (0.823), and Ireland (0.807). The United States is 28th with an index of 0.740; it scores well in all respects except political empowerment, where its score is a dismal 0.162.

How do gender egalitarian values compare with these measures of gender equality? My argument is that you can predict the extent of structural gender equality from the extent of how egalitarian gender attitudes are. A recent global survey asked women and men in twenty-four countries to answer ten questions about gender norms and expectations for men and women; the countries were ranked on the level of progressive gender attitudes. Matching the index of gender equality, the Nordic countries had the highest level of progressive gender attitudes (YouGov 2015). In Sweden, there was very little difference between women's and men's attitudes. The United States ranked ninth.

Other correlations of gender equality and progressive gender attitudes could be devised. In the United States, for instance, corporations could be ranked on the extent of their paid parental leave and the percentage of women executives. I would expect slippage in the correlations, which could then be explored in greater depth.

Avoiding Gender Binaries in Research and Practice

Queer studies has been a concerted effort to interrogate sexuality and gender and to deconstruct their normative assumptions of heterosexuality and binary gender but there has been a concomitant critique that “desire for gender” reinstates heterosexuality and its normativeness (Jeffreys 1996; Wiegman 2006).

Sociological research has expanded binary genders through intersectionality, where gender is sliced up by categories of race, ethnicity, social class, place of residence, and so on (McCall 2001). Gender begins as a binary variable, but it is broken up by the other variables so that the end result is multiple statuses in a stratified social structure, the equivalent of multiple genders that are not just individual identities. That is, the comparisons are not global categories of men versus women but categories such as White working class single mother and Black married woman executive. These are individual and group identities with behavioral sequelae and material effects. However, initial categorizations of gender in major survey research instruments are conceptually flawed in that they often do not clearly distinguish sex and gender or recognize gender variations, nor do they allow for changes in gender over time (Westbrook and Saperstein 2015).

It is possible to do research that does not start with binary gender categories but predicts behavior from processes and social locations, examining what people do to and with whom and how these processes construct institutional rules and social structures (Lorber 1996). Gender and other status variables can be correlated to emergent patterns later in the analysis, rather than beginning with the assumption that these variables are the starting point for behavior. Among useful methodologies are analysis of positions in a social network (Knoke and Yang 2008) and grounded theory (Charmaz 2014).

On the level of interactional practices that could undercut the gendering that supports gender-unequal policies I have proposed degendering focused on sorting people and allocating tasks in work organizations, schools, small groups, families, and other familiar social groupings (Lorber 2005). Degendered practices would encourage a gender-neutral division of labor in the home and gender-neutral jobs in workplaces, not grouping children by gender in schools, confronting gender expectations in face-to-face interaction, underplaying gender categories in language, and using gender-neutral kinship and relational designations.

Theoretically, degendered practices should feed into degendered official policies and ultimately into legal and bureaucratic statuses, but without a concerted movement for change, I do not think there will ever be a gradual progression into a social structure without gender.

Conclusion

Multiple genders may seem revolutionary, but they are not. First, they are personal identities, not legal or bureaucratic statuses. As such, they are not getting built into the structure of gender, which remains binary. Second, their individualistic rebelliousness does not encourage coalescence into a gender-resistant movement.

Queer studies, intersectionality, and nongendered research methods provide a basis for a transformation of sociological research and theorizing on gender. They could give us the data for policies that advance gender equality by challenging the legal rigidity of gender statuses, their constant use in the allocation of family work and paid jobs, and the consequent imbalance of economic resources and political power. At the same time, everyone, not just those who adopt nonbinary gender identities, could challenge the gender binary by not doing gender. Paradoxically, it's possible to be gendered and to try as much as possible to make one's gender irrelevant.

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